

MAYS BUSINESS SCHOOL
Office of the Dean

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Associate Director of Faculty Administration and Accreditation
Kenan-Flagler Business School
The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Dear Ms. Albertson,

Thank you for inviting me to provide an assessment of Dr. Sriram Venkataraman's scholarly contributions in connection with his case for promotion to Distinguished (Chair) Professor with Tenure in the Marketing Area at the Kenan-Flagler Business School, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill. It is an honor to evaluate a scholar whose work I have followed with great interest for many years. As a former Editor-in-Chief of the *Journal of Marketing* and a researcher in marketing strategy, I have read and cited Dr. Venkataraman's articles, and I have reviewed his work for our flagship journals. Our interactions have been entirely professional. We have not co-authored any papers nor worked at the same institution, and our paths have crossed at professional meetings and consortia rather than in any collaborative capacity. I can therefore offer an independent and well-informed assessment of the quality, significance, and impact of his research, teaching, and service.

I am familiar with Sri's published research and his expertise in the empirical study of marketing in regulated industries: pharmaceutical marketing and public health, the federal auto bailout and the durable goods sector, omnichannel marketing, and social media. A signature theme that runs through his program is the empirical study of how marketing and public policy interact, in industries that together account for a meaningful share of the U.S. economy. I believe Sri's research record is excellent in terms of both quality and quantity, and I will elaborate on each in turn.

Quantity and placement of research

In terms of research productivity, Sri has already published 14 peer-reviewed journal articles, with the bulk of those articles appearing in the field's most selective outlets: *Marketing Science* (six articles), *Management Science* (three articles), *Journal of Marketing Research* (two articles), *Journal of Marketing* (one article), and journals in adjacent disciplines including the *American Economic Review* (Papers and Proceedings) and the *Review of Financial Studies*. His pipeline is equally serious: two papers are currently in the third round of review, one at *Marketing Science* and one at *Science*. Several additional papers are being prepared for resubmission to *Marketing Science*, the *Journal of Marketing Research*, and *Management Science*. His Google Scholar record stands at nearly 4,000 citations with an H-index of 16, an unusually high citation profile for a quantitative marketing scholar in his cohort.

A submission under third-round review at *Science* deserves special note. If accepted, it would represent a landmark for the visibility of marketing scholarship in the broader scientific community and would mark Sri as one of the small group of marketing scholars whose work crosses into the world's most demanding general-science venues. The placement profile, taken with the post-full-professor research output and the depth of his pipeline, makes the productivity case clear. Sri's scholarly output since his promotion to Full Professor demonstrates momentum, not tapering, and his research record matches what one expects of a Distinguished Chair holder at a leading research institution.

Quality, significance, and intellectual contributions

What about the quality of Sri's work? Sri's scholarship demonstrates great care and focus in establishing and "owning" a domain. He has positioned himself among the first generation of quantitative marketing

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scholars who have taken seriously the empirical study of regulated industries: pharmaceuticals, automobiles, healthcare, and digital platforms. He has done so by combining institutional knowledge of these sectors with a methodological toolkit that spans structural econometric models, spatio-temporal models, regression discontinuity in time, instrumental variables, and difference-in-differences designs, always selected in service of the research question. Having published in marketing strategy and reviewed at the journals where Sri's work has appeared, I can assess the quality of his contributions with some confidence.

There appear to be four clear differentiators in Sri's contribution to the body of knowledge in marketing and public policy.

First, Sri has built a programmatic body of work on pharmaceutical marketing and public health, a domain that requires patient familiarity with regulatory institutions and access to specialized data. In Venkataraman and Stremersch (2007, *Management Science*), he showed that drug characteristics, specifically effectiveness and side-effect profiles, are the missing link that prior studies of physician detailing failed to account for, and that, once these characteristics are controlled for, physicians do carefully weigh information from firms and patients. In Liu, Gupta, Venkataraman, and Liu (2015, *Management Science*), he advanced a structural model that captures how firms compete dynamically when scheduling detailing visits, and showed that policies restricting access to physicians actually benefit firms with the weakest detailing effects and harm those with the strongest. In Stremersch, Landsman, and Venkataraman (2013, *Marketing Science*), he traced the chain from direct-to-consumer advertising to patient drug requests to physician prescribing behavior, with findings on racial and socioeconomic disparities in physician responsiveness that remain highly relevant to current debates about health equity. The cumulative effect of this stream is to give the marketing field a credible empirical voice in pharmaceutical regulatory debates that previously turned almost entirely on health-economics evidence.

Second, Sri has a clear penchant for substantively important problems and for clever identification strategies that allow those problems to be answered. The most striking example is his program of work on the 2008 federal auto bailout and its consequences. In Hortacsu, Matvos, Syverson, and Venkataraman (2013, *Review of Financial Studies*), he addressed the empirical challenge of measuring how automakers' financial distress affects consumer demand, where the obvious reverse-causality concern is that demand shocks themselves induce financial distress. His resolution, comparing shifts in used-car prices to manufacturers' bankruptcy likelihood measured by credit default swap spreads, is the kind of design that immediately reads as right and that has been adopted by subsequent work in finance and economics on bank failures. The companion paper in the *American Economic Review* (Papers and Proceedings, 2011) closed the loop by showing empirically that, while financial distress can substantially reduce automakers' profits, it is not large enough to trigger the bank-run-like effects that defenders of the warranty program had feared. Both papers were selected for presentation at the NBER's Industrial Organization and Corporate Finance meetings, a distinction awarded to a small handful of papers per year and to fewer marketing scholars still. The downstream papers in this stream, including Ozturk, Venkataraman, and Chintagunta (2016, *Marketing Science*) on price reactions to rivals' channel exits and Ozturk, Chintagunta, and Venkataraman (2019, *Marketing Science*) on consumer response to Chapter 11 bankruptcies, build on the same identification logic and use regression-discontinuity-in-time and related causal designs to recover credible effects from the unprecedented restructuring of the U.S. auto industry. I had not read all of these papers in detail before being asked to write this letter, and I found myself genuinely engaged by the discipline with which the identification strategies are layered against the institutional structure of the bailout.

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Third, Sri's work blends rigorous methods drawn from marketing, economics, finance, and operations, and the field has rewarded that interdisciplinary positioning. He has co-authored with Pradeep Chintagunta, Stefan Stremersch, Sridhar Gupta, Ali Hortacsu, Chad Syverson, Gregor Matvos, Rajdeep Grewal, Preyas Desai, and Sandy Jap, among others, which is itself a signal of how the field has integrated his work across subfields. He has published in *Marketing Science*, the *Journal of Marketing*, the *Journal of Marketing Research*, *Management Science*, the *American Economic Review*, and the *Review of Financial Studies*. You will be hard pressed to find a marketing scholar who has placed work across that span of outlets. Interdisciplinary work faces what I have come to call the "heterogeneous reviewer" hurdle, where reviewers from different fields apply different standards and where convergence is slow. Sri has cleared that hurdle multiple times, and the methodological innovations in his work, especially the data-enrichment approach in Kappe, Venkataraman, and Stremersch (2017, *Journal of Marketing Research*) and the spatio-temporal demand models in his auction and theater papers, are now being adopted by other scholars working on parallel questions.

Fourth, the field and the world outside the field have actively recognized the significance of Sri's work. He was selected in 2018 to the inaugural class of MSI Marketing Scholars, identifying him as one of the top 30 marketing scholars worldwide from the 2004-2008 graduating cohorts, one of the most selective career-stage distinctions in our field. His work on the federal auto bailout was referenced by the White House and analysts at the Federal Reserve Board. His policy-oriented research has been recognized by the Government of India through the Indian Institute of Management-Bangalore Challenge Research Grant, administered by the Office of the Prime Minister of India. He has briefed the Federal Trade Commission Commissioner on his extended-warranty research and presented findings to senior officials at the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services and the RAND Corporation. He has been retained as Meta's marketing expert witness in multiple high-profile federal and state litigations on social media. His collaboration with the Chief Economic Advisor of the Government of India on the evaluation of the Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana program, the world's largest public secondary and tertiary-care health insurance program, was incorporated into the Indian government's Economic Survey 2020-21 and underlies his *Science* submission. The pattern across these engagements is consistent. Sri's scholarship has reached the most consequential decision-makers in his domains: federal regulators, foreign governments, sovereign legal proceedings, and the boards of major digital platforms. That kind of practice and policy footprint is rare in our field and is exactly the profile that an Endowed Chair appointment is designed to recognize.

Comparison with peers at top 20 schools

The Kenan-Flagler instructions ask me to compare Sri's contributions with those of his cohort at peer top-20 institutions. I will be candid. The combination of (a) sustained publication in the field's premier journals across two decades, (b) a credible *Science* submission in the third round, (c) inclusion in the inaugural class of MSI Marketing Scholars, (d) work referenced by the White House, the Federal Reserve, the Government of India, and the FTC, (e) retention as a marketing expert witness by Meta in federal and state litigation, and (f) a record of serious institution-building service inside Kenan-Flagler is a profile that very few of his cohort at any top-20 marketing department can match. There are scholars in his cohort with higher raw publication counts and scholars with higher citation counts. There are very few who combine the publication record, the methodological range, the policy footprint, and the willingness to step into demanding institutional roles in the way that Sri has.

Service, mentorship, and institution-building

Sri's service contributions since his promotion to Full Professor are equally distinctive, and they are precisely the kind of contributions that a Distinguished Chair appointment should recognize and reward.

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Between 2021 and 2025, he served as Assistant Dean of the Full-Time MBA Program (2021-2022), Assistant Dean of the MBAUNC Online Program (2022-2023), and then Associate Dean of the MBAUNC Program (2023-2025). He led the Full-Time MBA program through the most demanding stretch of the COVID and post-COVID transition, including the launch of the school's first pre-MBA Business Foundations curriculum, which continues to serve every incoming Full-Time MBA cohort. As Associate Dean of the Online MBA program, he led the multi-year redesign that launched in January 2026, including a substantially restructured curriculum and the introduction of an AI Fluency core course that positions Kenan-Flagler as one of the first flagship MBA programs to embed AI literacy as a mandatory competency. He stepped out of the Dean's office in mid-2025 with faculty approval secured for the redesigned program, and on his return to the marketing area he was asked to take on the role of Marketing Area PhD Program Coordinator, which he now holds.

He has chaired or co-chaired multiple doctoral dissertations. His former doctoral student O. Cem Ozturk is a tenured Full Professor at the University of South Carolina's Darla Moore School of Business. His committee work has placed students at the University of Iowa, Georgia Tech, Texas A&M University, Indiana University, and the University of Western Ontario. His service to the discipline includes editorial board service at *Marketing Science* (2015-2022) and the *Journal of Marketing Research* (2018-2022), Guest Area Editor at the *Journal of Marketing Research*, and ad-hoc reviewing for *Marketing Science*, the *Journal of Marketing Research*, the *Journal of Marketing*, *Management Science*, the *International Journal of Research in Marketing*, *Quantitative Marketing and Economics*, the *American Economic Review*, the *Journal of Political Economy*, the *RAND Journal of Economics*, and the *Quarterly Journal of Economics*.

Teaching

Although I have not observed Sri's classroom directly, his teaching record is one I find easy to credit. He has been recognized as an MBA All-Star Teacher at UNC in nearly every academic year he has taught the elective since 2012, a sustained run of student recognition unusual in any MBA program. He has built and continues to lead the school's MBA Pricing Strategy and Tactics elective across the Full-Time, Evening and Weekend, and Online MBA formats, and he has developed two distinct online electives, MBA 760A: Pricing Strategy and MBA 760B: Pricing Analytics, that reflect a serious pedagogical philosophy about how to teach experienced professionals. He is the faculty of record for Kenan-Flagler's introductory Python for Business Analytics course, and he is a core developer of the school's inaugural AI Fluency course launching in July 2026. He continues to teach a doctoral seminar in Structural Models in Marketing that draws PhD students from both UNC and Duke. The Gerald Barrett Faculty Award he received for his contributions to the MBA program, awarded at the close of the largest Full-Time MBA class he led, is consistent with the rest of the teaching record.

The most significant publications, and any weaknesses

Among Sri's published work, the three I find most consequential are Hortacsu, Matvos, Syverson, and Venkataraman (2013, *Review of Financial Studies*) on automakers' financial distress and consumer demand, Stremersch, Landsman, and Venkataraman (2013, *Marketing Science*) on direct-to-consumer advertising and physician prescribing, and Liu, Gupta, Venkataraman, and Liu (2015, *Management Science*) on dynamic detailing competition. Each is methodologically demanding, each connects to a question of public and policy importance, and each has been adopted by subsequent scholarship in marketing and adjacent fields. The Chintagunta, Gopinath, and Venkataraman (2010, *Marketing Science*) paper on online user reviews and movie box-office performance is among the most cited papers ever published at *Marketing Science* and is the foundation of the marketing-expert work that Meta has retained him for. The current pipeline of sole-authored work, including the third-round *Science*

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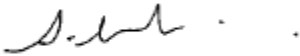
submission and the *Marketing Science* submission on B2B auction assortments, addresses any residual question about individual contribution.

In sum

Sri Venkataraman is an outstanding scholar, a service-oriented professional, and a leader in his field. The Kenan-Flagler guidelines for promotion emphasize sustained contribution to knowledge, demonstrated impact on managerial practice and the research literature, sustained productivity in high-quality refereed outlets, and significant national and international recognition. In my judgment, Sri meets, and in several respects exceeds, every one of these criteria. He has my strongest and unequivocal recommendation for promotion to Distinguished (Chair) Professor with Tenure at the Kenan-Flagler Business School. I am confident he will continue to advance the field of marketing, the standing of marketing scholarship in the broader policy and scientific community, and Kenan-Flagler's stature in research, teaching, and service.

Should you require further information, please do not hesitate to contact me at ssridhar@mays.tamu.edu.

Sincerely,



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